



Cover story **BARACK OBAMA**

Council (USBC) concluded the largest-ever American commercial nuclear executive mission to India that had representatives from 39 of its top companies.

The real concern for India is Obama's advocacy of having America ratify the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT). Although the US signed the treaty during Clinton's presidency, the US Congress has so far not ratified it. The Bush administration was dead set against ratifying it. But with the Democrats taking control of both houses of Congress, Obama's advisers are optimistic of pushing it through when the CTBT comes up for review next year. Other US experts think it may not be such an easy task. Schaffer points out that ratification requires two-thirds of the Senate to vote for it, which means that seven Republicans need to back it. Also, she argues that there is a heavy load of Congressional priorities that include the domestic economy and Iraq and therefore treaty ratifications may be pushed to the background.

If the Obama administration is able to push through the CTBT ratification, it would put India in a bind. India had so far refused to sign it by pointing out that the treaty was discriminatory as the US and China still had to ratify it. But that would not hold once the US signs with China likely to follow suit. Although India has declared a unilateral moratorium on testing, some experts hold that there may be a need to test its weapon designs in future. Krepon believes that in the US Senate, the Democrats would make "some trade-offs with Republicans who will be required to be assured that, until the US gets to zero nuclear weapons, the declining US stockpile is reliable, safe and secure". It could possibly imply developing new and more reliable weapons. It could be an excuse for India to insist on keeping its option to test

open. The CTBT is a major issue that India may find itself in variance, even conflict, with the Obama administration.

DOES OBAMA HAVE A KASHMIR AGENDA?

Even before he was sworn in as President, Obama's statements on India's relations with Pakistan and the Kashmir issue made Delhi wince on several occasions. In an interview with *Time* he talked of Kashmir being a "a potential tar pit diplomatically" and the need to appoint a special envoy to solve it. Obama agitated South Block mandarins further when in another interview he stated, "The most important thing we're going to have to do with respect to Afghanistan is actually deal with Pakistan. And we've got to work with the newly-elected government in Pakistan in a coherent way that says, terrorism is now a threat to you. Extremism is a threat to you. We should try to resolve the Kashmir crisis so that Pakistan can stay focused not on India, but on the situation with those militants."

It may make India hot under the collar but the logic of Obama's team as put forth by Hillary Clinton, his secretary of state, in her testimony to the Senate, is that the security situation is deteriorating rapidly in Afghanistan with the Taliban gaining ground. So the new strategy for Afghanistan is to end the war in Iraq "responsibly" and then send additional US troops to Afghanistan to complete the mission there.

Part of that would be to develop "a coherent Pakistan policy" to prevent the Taliban from using Pakistani territory as a haven. So while US military aid is to be conditioned to tackle terror, non-military aid is to be tripled to improve the lives of the average Pakistani and "reduce the pull of extremists". To enable Pakistan to be

THE A-TEAM

The people in Obama's team that India will need to work with

Robert Gates *Defence Secretary*



Gates is the face of continuity. India can look forward to enhancing defence ties

with the US, whether purchasing hi-tech equipment or joint patrols of the seas.

Tim Geithner *Treasury Secretary*



As spear-head of the trillion-dollar bailout and architect of America's plan to re-

vive the economy, Geithner is a man that India will have to keep a close watch on.

Susan Rice *Ambassador to the UN*



The candid Rice prefers a strong UN role in Iraq, Afghanistan. Wants Iran's nuclear am-

bitions curbed, a greater US role on climate change and is proactive on Kashmir.

Steven Chu *Energy Secretary*



A renewable energy enthusiast, Chu can help India move towards clean, green

technologies that could help revolutionise power consumption patterns.

hard focused on the task, the US wants India and Pakistan to have a credible dialogue over Kashmir. But as Naresh Chandra, a former Indian ambassador to the US, points out: "In the process of balancing and give and take we will